

Defense, the internet had originally offered little or no ordinary public access. Berners-Lee left CERN in 1980, but returned in 1984 as a fellow. At that time, CERN was the largest internet node in Europe, and to modify it, Berners-Lee proposed the World Wide Web in 1989. This was a program that could enable users to access information via the internet using a "browser."

### Open access

From the start, Berners-Lee urged CERN to make the World Wide Web available to the world for free by putting it into the public domain instead of patenting it—a very generous decision that cost him billions. Fittingly, his first step once the Web went live on April 30, 1991, was to publish a manifesto that included detailed instructions for programmers on how they could build their own websites. Effectively the first ever webpage, this document outlined

**"The Web** does not just **connect machines,** it **connects people."**

Tim Berners-Lee, 2008

two ingeniously simple standards called HTML (hypertext markup language) and HTTP (hypertext transfer protocol). HTML is a standard way of coding webpages so that any computer can display them; HTTP is a "language" that allows the web browsers on people's computers to communicate with the web servers that store websites in HTML form.

Berners-Lee's invention soon gathered pace, partly due to the simplicity of HTML and HTTP, but also thanks to the development of secure, easy-to-use web browsers. By the mid-1990s, millions of people—home users, universities, scientists, governments, and businesses—were interacting, creating, selling, and shopping with the World Wide Web. In 1994, Berners-Lee set up the World Wide Web

**Thanks to Tim Berners-Lee's creation** of the World Wide Web, people are able to communicate via email and to conduct business electronically across the globe.

Consortium (W3C), which continues to develop the Web's open standards. But from the earliest days of his invention, he has consistently advocated for a fair, democratic, and truly "World Wide" Web that brings political, social, and economic benefits to everyone on the planet.

